Rishikesh

written by

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SCREENWRITERS ASSOCIATION

"If there is a God, He will have to beg for my forgiveness."

- Unknown Holocaust Victim

FADE IN:

INT. DOORSTEP - NIGHT

CLOSE-UP

AKANKSHA's pretty face, unmoving, wet, bloodied. Some stray strands of hair stuck to her forehead. She's dead. Her eyes are open, a horrifying and cold look in them.

ROHIT's anxious, disbelieving face fills the frame next. Bloodied, nostrils breathing rapidly. Teardrops, mixed with the raindrops trickle down from his face. He is panting, shaking. He wipes away his face with his right hand, and now a fresh layer of blood adorns his face.

WIDE-SHOT

Rohit stands next to the dead body of Akanksha, at the door of the mansion, just staring, unmoving, silent. The rain gets heavier, and with one loud lightning strike, we...

CUT TO:

SUPER on SCREEN- RISHIKESH

(Sounds of Rohit's grunts creep in as he drags the body in)

CUT TO:

INT. HALL - NIGHT

With one last forceful push, Rohit drags the body inside the house. He falls on his knees and shuts the door behind him with a loud grunt. He labors to pull the body to make it sit up against the door.

He drags some deep breaths and brings out a cigarette packet from his leather jacket. The cigarette packet is soaked and wasted. He throws it away in frustration and rushes inside the house to find another packet.

AKANKSHA'S POV

The hall is in full view. A peculiarly furnished, large hall, with medieval era paintings adorning the walls. Some dark colored curtains block the windows, arranged asymmetrically. A massive table in the right corner where the kitchen partition begins.

Rohit looks for a fresh cigarette packet on the table, finds it among the clutter, lights one up, sits on the chair, and stares at the dead body as he releases a thick cloud of smoke.

A BLINK!

Rohit is on his guard, he gets up, and walks closer to the body. He bends down and checks the pulse. He is relieved. He cups the eyes with his left hand, and we dip to black.

AKANKSHA'S POV ENDS.

Rohit is sitting beside the body, smoking a cigarette, breathing normally now, staring at Akanksha's beautiful face.

Rohit observes her body and rubs his finger on her face.

SUPER- THE OBNOXIOUS WRITER

The deathly silence of the moment is shaken by a loud phone ringtone.

Rohit moves some stuff around the table and finds his phone. He sits on the chair, removing his shoes and socks.

It's his agent/friend, SAHIL. Rohit picks the phone up. He feels some relief.

ROHIT
Hello! Sahil!

SAHIL (O.S.)
Kahaan mar gaya saale? Phone kyu nahi utha raha tha.

Rohit picks up the printed DEVNAGRI manuscript titled 'JANARDAN' from the table and observes the handmade sketch on the cover.

CUT TO:

ANIME SEQUENCE - CUTAWAY

Janardan, is standing with a snake wrapped around his neck, staring into the camera. Tall, curly hair, sinister look on his face.

CUT TO:

Rohit is trying to keep his composure.

ROHIT
Yahi tha... uh... sun ... abhi aakhri chapter pe hun, ek hafta aur pakad ke chal.

A Beat.

SAHIL (O.S.)
Pichhle hafte bhi 1 hafta bola tha. Bhenchod, hafta nahi, tujhe 1 din de raha hun main. Maar kyu nahi deta Janardan ko? Tere fuffa ka beta lagta hai kya wo jo itna senti ho raha hai?

Rohit swirls his fingers on Janardan's thin face on the cover.

ROHIT
Paagal ho gaya hai kya? Sequel ka plan hai mera. Thoda time de abhi. Aur, um...

ROHIT (CONT'D)
Sun...
(A BEAT)

ROHIT (CONT'D)
Yar, ek thoda sa scene ho gaya.

SAHIL (O.S.)
Kya??

ROHIT
Um... Akanksha, mar gayi hai!

Silence.

SAHIL (O.S.)
Tune maara?

ROHIT
Nahi bey. Bas... wo mar gayi yar...

SAHIL (O.S.)
Bina maare koi kaise mar skta hai bhai? Kya scene hai bhenchod?

ROHIT
Bhai fatti padi hai, tu aa sakta hai kya?

SAHIL (O.S.)
Mujhe pata to tha kisi din to kaand karega tu gaandu. Suicide kiya kya usne?

ROHIT
Nahi. Uski umm... kamar se khoon nikal raha hai.

Rohit sighs.

SAHIL (O.S.)
Theek hai.

ROHIT
Isme theek kya hai saaley?

SAHIL (O.S.)
Aur kya bolu? Aur tune theek se check kiya na? Pakka mar gayi hai na, ya behosh wehosh hui hai?

ROHIT
Pakka kachha kya hota hai lodu? Mujhe nahi pata kya ki marna kya hota hai? Heartbeat nahi hai. Aur body ka wajan 10-12 kilo badh gaya hai.

Rohit walks up to the body and checks the pulse again.

SAHIL (O.S.)
Arey dalle. Jail bhijwayega tu bc. Tu wahee ruk. Kuch mat kariyo mere aane se pehle. Laash kahan hai?

ROHIT
Idhar hi hai. Mere saamne.

SAHIL (O.S.)
Tu kahin chhupa na use. Koi aa gaya to?

ROHIT
Haan sahee keh raha hai. Karta hun.

SAHIL (O.S.)
Chal wait kar fir. Saaley ek book ke chakkar mein aisi taisi karwa raha hai meri.
(screams to his mom)
Mummy, suno. Rishikesh jaa raha hun, Ganga nahaane.

MOTHER (O.S.)
Pagal wagal ho gaya hai?

SAHIL (O.S.)
Maa, 35 ka ho gaya hun, kuch to apni marzi se...

Sahil cuts the call.

Rohit hangs up the call.

He looks at the clock on the wall. It's 10:20 PM.

CUT TO:

INT. HALL - NIGHT

Rohit drags the body through the damp floor, which is leaving a trail of blood in the room. Rohit's wet clothes further leave a trail of wetness on the shiny, light coloured floor.

Rohit drags a deep breath.

CUT TO:

INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT

(FLASHBACK)

Rohit exhales... struggles to catch his breath. His sweaty face is red, and smiling in pleasure.

He's on the bed, above Akanksha, who's panting, too. Aftermath of an intense sex session. They are fully clothed.

Akanksha grabs her head.

AKANKSHA
Shit. Jaan se maarne ka iraada tha kya?

She smiles.

Rohit falls to the other side of the bed. Akanksha's eyes seek validation as she looks at him. Rohit's staring at the ceiling, his chest heaving loudly. Rohit drags up his pants.

ROHIT
Shut up.

Akanksha smiles.

AKANKSHA
Just... why are you so afraid of death. Aisa to hai nahi ki we're gonna live forever or anything.

Rohit throws a side glance at her.

AKANKSHA (CONT'D)
Achha main kya soch rahi thi. Janardan agar suicide kar le, to sense nahi banega kya?

ANIME SEQUENCE - CUTAWAY

Janardan is preparing to jump from a cliff, his pet snake curled up around his waist, spreading his hood over his shoulder.

CUT TO:

AKANKSHA (CONT'D)
Aur agar afterlife mein wo apne papa aur abni biwi se milke apna trauma resolve karle, to? Kaisa sound ho raha hai?

Rohit thinks for a moment, then looks at her lovingly.

ROHIT
Ek bahut bure writer jaisa sound ho raha hai. Tu agar thodi si kam sundar hoti na, to mai shayad seriously le leta teri baat ko.

Akanksha frowns.

AKANKSHA
Seriously soch ke dekho? Is guilt ke saath zinda rehna maut se bhi zyada bhayanak nahi hai? I think he should die.

Rohit smiles.

ROHIT
Sahil ne patti padha di kya?

Akanksha smiles.

AKANKSHA
(sarcastic)
Haan, haan. Usise to shaadi karne jaa rahi hun agle hafte.

Rohit jumps from the bed and stretches his body.

ROHIT
Saala roz meri jaan khata hai ki Janardan ko maar du main, aur kitaab khatm karun. Aise thodi na hota hai. Is chutiye se milke samajh aata hai ye agents kabhi khud writer kyun nahi ban paate.

Akanksha gets off the bed.

AKANKSHA
Par soch to sab sakte hi hain, nahi?

ROHIT
Shalini bhi?

This gets to Akanksha. She throws an unkind glare towards him.

Rohit smiles.

He walks over to a cupboard and opens it.

(FLASHBACK ENDS)

Rohit, now with a bloodied, messy face, attempts to push Akanksha's body into the same cupboard.

His bare feet slip a few times, he pulls his body up, and with great difficulty, he somehow manages to shove the body inside, and shuts the cupboard.

From another cupboard, he brings out new clothes and rips open his wet shirt and trousers.

CUT TO:

He throws his clothes in the machine.

INT. DINING TABLE - NIGHT

Rohit, looking cleaner now, with a change of clothes and blood wiped away from his face, lights a cigarette. The table is cluttered, stacked full of books, a watch, pens, a laptop, papers, the manuscript, a bottle of whiskey, two glasses, and some painkillers.

Rohit chugs down two painkillers with a half-drunk glass of whiskey.

He bangs the glass down on the table, near the copy of his unfinished manuscript.

Right next to it is his published book titled SHANTANU AUR PAHAAD MEIN EK MAUT. It has a 'Best-Seller' laurel at the bottom along with his name- ROHIT SINGH.

His hand reaches his published book, then THUD!

The deathly silence of the room is rocked by a loud thud blasting from the bedroom. Rohit turns his head towards the bedroom, with panic-stricken eyes. Eyebrows raised, racing heartbeat.

THUD! THUD! THUD!

Rohit jerks.

ROHIT
Kyaa...

Rohit stands up and stares at the bedroom door, fear gripping the depths of his soul.

One more THUD and he is about to cry!

ROHIT (CONT'D)
Akanksha? Tum ho kya?

THUD, THUD, THUD.

Shifting into a defensive stance, Rohit slowly walks over to the bedroom.

He is panicking.

ROHIT (CONT'D)
Akanksha?

CUT TO:

INT. BEDROOM - NIGHT

Rohit slowly opens the door and enters. The damp air in room makes him sweat through his neck.

The persistent thud fills the atmosphere with eeriness. Rohit's heartbeat rises as he attempts to make sense of the sound with a scowl. He pulls in air, is about to scream- when...

The thud stops.

EXTREME CLOSEUP: Rohit's face, with searching eyes, as he tries to gauge any movement that might be happening inside the cupboard.

Silence.

Slow DOLLY IN: the cupboard, slow push in until we reach the cupboard's handle, smeared with stains of blood.

Nothing. No sound. No movement.

Rohit relaxes and flashes a nervous smile.

He quickly opens the drawer. The body is tucked inside, the way he stacked it.

He wipes the blood, and walks back to the hall.

CUT TO:

INT. - DINING TABLE - NIGHT

Rohit walks out of the bedroom, shutting the door behind him. He walks backwards looking at the dining table, and just as he turns towards the table, his face turns pale.

Akanksha, in the brown sundress, bloodied around her neck, is sitting on the table, staring at him. And then she slowly opens her mouth and utters in a scary ghostly hoarse voice!

AKANKSHA
Rohit, Janardan ko maar do, warna wo tumhein maar dega!

Rohit screams and rushes into the kitchen. He shuffles through knives of all sizes, picks the longest one, and rushes back to the table.

There's nobody there.

With a defensive stance, Rohit lurks around the entire hall. Suddenly, it feels claustrophobic. There's a small table, on which a 3-foot idol of Lord Shiva, with the snake draped around his neck, is flashing neon lights, making a whoosh sound.

The other wall has a tall painting 'SATURN DEVOURING HIS SON', and the adjacent wall is fully covered in a shiny black drape with golden embroidery, in the shape of a monster.

Rohit swallows. Perhaps it was just a HALLUCINATION.

He sighs and walks over to the dining table, calms himself down, and digs himself in the chair.

He screams- "Akanksha."

CUT TO:

(FLASHBACK)

Akanksha walks in from the kitchen. She is in a relaxed fit shirt and shorts, her hands smeared with flour.

AKANKSHA (CONT'D)
Chilla kyu rahe ho? Bhoot woot dekh liya kya?

Rohit, in a black shirt and blue jeans, is sitting on the chair, looking at his phone. He is scowling.